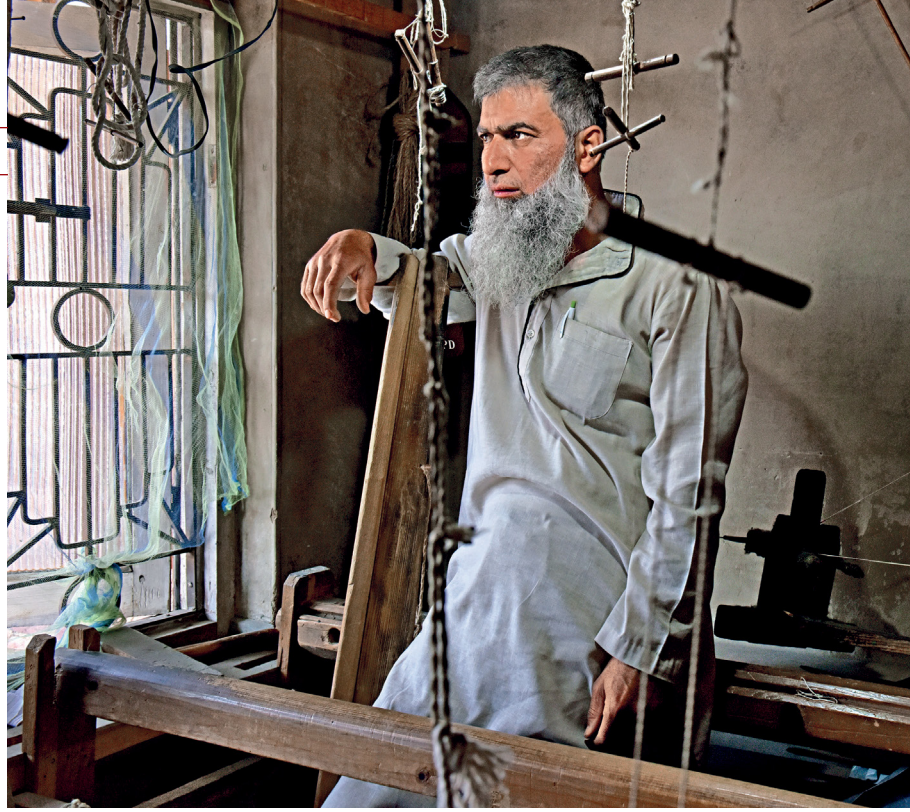


Pashmina wool is sourced from the Changthang goats in Ladakh. From raw wool to a finished shawl is a process as labour-intensive as it's skilful: involving dehairing, scouring, bleaching, spinning, weaving, dyeing, finishing, cleaning and embroidery. An original Pashmina fetches thousands of dollars in the international market.

Yet, deplorably, the very men who toil unceasingly to create these achingly beautiful objects are underpaid, caught in a cycle of poverty and increasingly driven to leave the profession. As a result, crafts honed over centuries are inching towards extinction. Hussain, who is 52-years-old and a father of three, regrets taking up the craft. "My children would weep when they left for school because I could not afford a packet of biscuits or snacks for them," he says. Hussain has now quit the trade and signed up as a salesman at a sanitaryware shop. As he runs his fingers through a salt-and-pepper beard, he seems a content man—he now earns three times as much as he did making shawls.

According to Hussain, his craft as a weaver brought him only Rs 300, while unskilled labourers earn above Rs 700 a day and get social security benefits. "As a weaver...I could not afford my children's tuition fees. Others make money out of our hard work, while we become poorer by the day." Faced with an irremediable situation, artisans avoid passing their skills to their offspring. Many, like Hussain, won't even let their children set eyes on the looms that once sustained their families.

An official document cites that production of handmade carpets, kani shawls, Khatamband woodwork, namda rugs, papier mache objects and walnut wood carving is facing an acute manpower crunch. However, since Kashmir handicrafts is an unorganised sector, accurate data about artisans quitting the sector is hard to come by. Prof Imtiyaz-ul-Haq, head of the economics department at Kashmir University, explains that Kashmir is a labour deficient economy and almost

FOREIGN EXPORTS OF KASHMIRI HANDICRAFTS HAVE FALLEN STEEPLY OVER THE PAST DECADE. ARTISANS ATTRIBUTE IT TO MACHINE-MADE PRODUCTS SOLD AS 'GENUINE' KASHMIR PRODUCTS THAT ULTIMATELY DEVALUE THE BRAND

800,000 migrant workers come here for work annually. Consequently, labour wages have shot up, resulting in low-paid skilled artisans quitting their trades and taking up menial jobs, such as construction labour. This has resulted in a decline in production and export of Kashmiri handicrafts.

For instance, nonagenarian Ghulam Mohammad and his four sons did walnut carving, but not a single member of the next generation have taken up the job. Instead, they have moved to the West Asia to work and are now prompting their fathers to quit the craft. "Our children were not willing to allow us to carry on with our *karkhana*," says Zahoor Ahmad, citing the reason for quitting the trade. Besides low wages, Hussain attributes the steady attenuation to a 'slow poisoning'—eye problems and orthopaedic issues are common afflictions among weavers and embroiderers. "This trade sucks the blood of craftsmen, but all we get is exploitation," he says.

While Europe is still enamoured of Kashmiri handicraft, it also has a large market in West Asia and China. Over 900,000 people are associated with the trade, including 280,000 artisans registered with the government's handicrafts and handlooms department—66,000 are weavers, the rest are engaged in walnut wood carving, papier mache craft, crewel embroidery and other trades. But here, too, there is approaching gloom—annual trade has fallen steeply, with foreign exports dwindling in the past decade. From nearly Rs 1,700 crore in 2013, annual exports have dipped to Rs 563